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**A SMALL
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OFFICE**

AMIT CHINCHOLIKAR

GLOBAL CHRO, TATA
CONSUMER PRODUCTS

sional Mohammed Sulaiman, who is currently living with his family in Chennai. He has to report back at work in Bengaluru for two days a week. Wary of Bengaluru's infamous traffic and mindful of the rent he will have to shell out, he plans to test the waters by shunting between the two cities every week for a month until he works out a good arrangement. "Compared to the previous times, the company is a lot more serious this time about returning to work and there have been multiple follow-ups about returning to work."

Employers, on their part, say they find a lot of value in bringing employees back, despite remote work not affecting productivity. It's not about the productivity, says Deepti Varma, Director-HR for Amazon in APAC and Middle East. "But it is important for us to continue to invest in culture, help the person learn the Amazon way of doing things, and enable social interactions among the teams so that the person feels more belonged at Amazon." The company, which topped this year's BT-Taggd Best Companies to Work For in India survey, allows team leaders to decide how many days employees need to work from office or home.

"If we are going to hire thousands of people and if all of them are just small boxes on a screen, then how are we going to build a connect?" asks HDFC Bank CHRO Vinay Razdan, adding that the lender has not issued a formal diktat to all employees to return. Periodic gathering is required, but within that there is enough flexibility to offer remote working to people, he says. But the reasons also extend to other factors like office space usage and better employee control, adds the senior HR professional who requested anonymity. "Not everybody has given up office space. So, what do you with an empty office? Besides, if you are at work and I've lost your mindshare, I can work on counselling, retention, and a lot of things. When you are not on my premises, I have to keep wondering if that sense of belonging is there."

Be that as it may, the fact is that employees may not have much choice if companies require them to return to office as long as the state and central governments' rules don't prohibit them from doing so. "In such a situation, employees cannot rightfully refuse to return to office if so mandated by their employer," says Rashmi Pradeep, Partner at legal firm Cyril Amarchand Mangaldas. The general opening up of the economy and lifting of restrictions also means that employers can take disciplinary action against employees who refuse to return and the employees would be left with limited legal recourse, she adds.

Naturally, there is no clear hybrid model winner yet, but the bigger companies will be the bellwethers, Das says. "The likes of TCS, Wipro, Google,

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**OUR
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S.V. NATHAN

PARTNER AND CHIEF TALENT
OFFICER, DELOITTE INDIA

